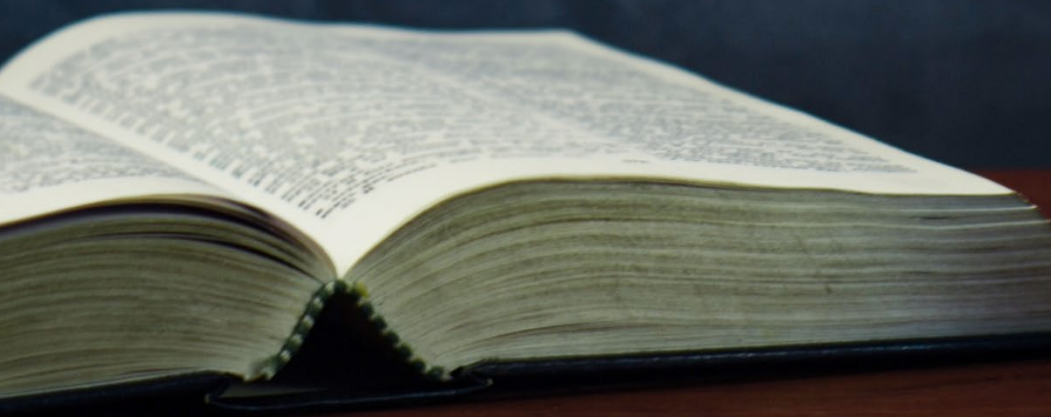


HOW TO STUDY LIKE A PASTOR



William CK Yomes

INTRODUCTION

You have probably read it more times than you can count. You have heard it in church, seen it on coffee mugs, and watched it scroll by on social media. You can probably recite parts of it from memory.

But here is an honest question: when you open your Bibles and read on your own, do you feel like you are actually gaining understanding from it?

Most believers quietly answer no — and then feel guilty about it, as though the problem is their faith rather than their method. They read a passage, feel a vague sense that something important just happened, and close the book without being able to say what it was. They try again the next morning. Same result. This is not a spiritual problem, a faith problem, or a maturity problem.

This is a method problem.

Reading the Bible and studying the Bible are not the same thing. Think of it this way. Imagine you are visiting a large, beautiful lake for the first time. If you want to see as much of it as possible, you will likely rent a powerful motorboat and speed around the shoreline, taking in the landscape and size of the lake. That is reading — you cover a lot of ground and see the shape and shoreline of the whole lake, and it is genuinely worthwhile.

But if you want to see into the lake — down into the depths where the real life is in the underwater ecosystem — you need a different boat entirely. A glass-bottom canoe, moving slowly, intentionally, barely disturbing the surface. That is how you will see down into the depths of the waters. That is studying. It is slower and takes more intentional effort, but what you see is completely different.

This guide is written to give you the canoe to explore the depths of your Bible.

Inside, you will find two tools that work together. The first is a framework for understanding the Bible's big story — because you cannot understand any passage without knowing where it fits in the whole. The second is a simple, repeatable four-step method for studying any passage of Scripture on our own, without a seminary degree, without an expensive library, and without feeling lost.

At the end, we will put both tools to work on one of the most familiar verses in the Bible — John 3:16 — and we will discover that a verse we thought we already knew is considerably deeper than we realized.

The Bible is not a difficult book that rewards only the academically gifted. It is a rich book that rewards anyone willing to slow down and look deeply. Let's do that together.

PART ONE THE BIG PICTURE: UNDERSTANDING THE STORY BEHIND THE VERSES

Before we can study any individual passage well, we need to understand the Bible as a whole. The Bible is a collection of sixty-six books, written by more than forty human authors across roughly 1,500 years, in three different languages, to wildly different audiences. And yet it tells one continuous story from the first page to the last.

Missing that story is like walking into a movie during the third act. We can follow what is happening on screen, but we are missing the weight of everything that led to this moment. The Bible's big story is the context that makes every individual passage make sense.

That big story of the Bible has four movements.

1. CREATION

In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth (Genesis 1:1). The story opens with a powerful Creator who makes the world over six days, calling each stage good. On the sixth day, He creates humanity — and the verdict upgrades to very good (Genesis 1:31). God then places the man and woman in a garden

called Eden, where He walks and talks with them in an easy, unbroken relationship (Genesis 2:8, 3:8).

This is the original design: humanity living in relationship with God in a creation that is very good. Everything in the Bible after this is the story of what happened to that design — and what God did to restore it.

Main Idea: Humanity was created to live in relationship with God in His "very good" creation.

2. CORRUPTION

In the middle of the garden, God placed two trees: the Tree of Life and the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. He gave one clear instruction — do not eat from the second tree. The consequence for disobedience would be death (Genesis 3:2).

Adam and Eve ate from the tree anyway. Their choice to put their own desires above God's design was the first human sin, and it cracked the world at its foundation (Genesis 3:12–19). Creation was no longer very good. Human relationships became difficult. Work became painful. And the perfect, effortless access to God that Adam and Eve enjoyed in the garden was broken.

Every hard thing in the world we live in — conflict, suffering, injustice, death — is a symptom of that

original fracture. The world we inhabit is a corruption of the one God designed.

Main Idea: The world we live in today is a corruption of God's original design. Creation needs to be redeemed.

3. REDEMPTION

Here is the problem the rest of the Bible is solving: the penalty for that original sin is the death of a sinless human being. But sin has now infected the entire human family. Every person born into this world inherits a nature bent toward choosing their own desires over God's design (John 3:3, Psalm 51:5). There is no one left who qualifies to pay the debt.

This is why God sent His own Son. Jesus, the Son of God, became a human being — born miraculously, living sinlessly, and dying as the full payment for what humanity owed (John 1:14, Romans 5:12). His death was not a tragedy that God rescued something good from. It was the whole plan.

Jesus is the only person in history who lived a sinless human life, died as payment for human sin, and rose from the grave to prove He is who He claimed to be. This is why salvation is only found in Him.

Main Idea: Jesus had to die as a sinless human being to pay the penalty for the original sin in Eden.

"For God so loved the world that He gave His one and only Son, that whoever believes in Him shall not perish but have eternal life." — John 3:16

4. RESTORATION

Redemption is purchased by Jesus, but the story is not finished. Creation is still broken. The world is still groaning under the weight of corruption (Romans 8:22). Those who trust in Jesus are forgiven and restored to relationship with God — but they still live in a fractured world, waiting for what comes next.

What comes next is restoration. In the final chapters of Revelation, the story of the Bible ends where it began: a new creation, no longer corrupted, where God lives with His people again (Revelation 21:1–4). Humanity is once again free to live in relationship with the Creator in a world that is, once again, very good.

The Bible is not a collection of moral lessons or inspirational stories loosely connected by a shared religion. It is one story, with a beginning, a crisis, a solution, and a resolution. Every passage we study lives somewhere in that arc.

Main Idea: While Jesus has already purchased forgiveness for sin, creation is still waiting for full restoration.

PART TWO THE METHOD: FOUR STEPS FOR STUDYING ANY PASSAGE

Now that we have the big story of the Bible in view, we need a method for looking carefully at the individual passages within it. The S.O.I.L. Method is exactly that — a simple, repeatable process we can apply to any text in Scripture. The underlying approach has been practiced by careful Bible students for centuries — scholars call it the grammatical-historical method. S.O.I.L. is simply my way of putting that method in blue jeans and a ball cap.

S.O.I.L. stands for Selection, Observation, Interpretation, and Life Application. Before walking through each step, pay attention to this time allocation:

10% Selection ·

50% Observation ·

30% Interpretation ·

10% Life Application

Notice that the final step — the one most people rush to first — receives the smallest share of time. The reason will become clear as we work through the steps. For now, simply trust the design: patience in the first three steps produces good fruit in the fourth. Rush to

application without doing the work first, and we risk misapplying the Scripture entirely.

Remember the canoe. This is a slow process. That is not a flaw. It's the whole point.

STEP 1: SELECT THE TEXT (10%) THE GOAL

Before we can study anything, we need to be clear about what we are studying. Write it down. Be specific.

Example: John 3:16 — or if we want the surrounding context, John 3:1–21.

Once we have selected our text, we ask a few orienting questions before doing anything else:

Who was the original author of this text? Who was the original audience? Where does this passage fit in the big Bible story? What comes immediately before and after this text? When did the events of this passage take place? What is the literary genre — is this poetry, narrative, letter, prophecy?

These questions orient us before we begin. We would not start a hike without knowing which trail we are on. Selection is putting on our boots and reading the trailhead map.

STEP 2: OBSERVE THE TEXT (50%) THE GOAL

This is the investigative reporter step. Our job is to interrogate the text and look for the who, where, when, and what details. We do not try to make sense of them yet. We just see what is there.

Write down everything we notice. This is the most important step and receives the most time for a reason — the quality of our interpretation in Step 3 is entirely dependent on the quality of our observations here. As an example, let's use John 3:16. Not just the verse, but the larger section around it as well.

Who?

Named individuals: David, Abraham, Peter,
Nicodemus

People groups: Jews, Gentiles, Samaritans, Egyptians

Implied groups: everyone, angels, soldiers

Titles: Pharisee, King, Centurion, Rabbi, Servant

Where?

Geography: Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, Corinth, Rome

Specific locations: the upper room, the Jordan River,
the Temple, the wilderness

When?

Specific times: nine in the morning, the sixth hour
Festivals or holy days: Pentecost, Sabbath, Passover
The passage of time: the next day, in the evening,
immediately
Event-triggered time: when he heard, after saying, as
soon as

What?

Physical objects: sheep, bread, stone, water, a bronze
snake on a pole

Actions: sat down, taught, baptized, wept, questioned

Themes: prayer, forgiveness, sin, grace, light, darkness

Write down every observation — even the ones that
seem obvious or unimportant. We cannot know yet
which details matter most. Cast a wide net. We can
narrow later.

STEP 3: INTERPRET THE TEXT (30%) THE GOAL

Now we begin to make sense of what we have seen.
We have a list of observations. Now we ask: what do
they mean?

Interpretation works through three categories of
questions.

LITERARY QUESTIONS

Are there key words, terms, or repeated themes in the text?

What do the original languages (Hebrew or Greek) reveal about specific terms?

Are significant words used elsewhere in the Bible?

What do those other uses tell us?

What does the literary context, what comes before and after, tell us about this passage?

HISTORICAL QUESTIONS

When and where did this passage take place?

What was the political or cultural landscape at the time?

What historical background helps explain why people acted as they did?

Where does this passage sit in the big Bible story?

THEOLOGICAL QUESTIONS

What does this passage teach about God Himself?

What does this passage teach about salvation, forgiveness, or grace?

What does it teach about humanity, sin, or judgment?

What does it teach about the Church or the Christian life?

Please keep in mind, these are abbreviated lists and

only represent some questions that should be asked in each category. These are just examples and you should develop your own lists of questions you bring to the text for your own investigations.

A practical word of advice here: do your own interpretation first. Write down what you think the observations mean before opening a commentary or a study Bible. Commentaries are valuable tools, and you should definitely add them to your collection of study tools — but they are the record of someone else's work. In many cases, Bible commentaries are the product of a team of highly educated and skilled people working together. If we skip our own interpretive work and go straight to what the commentary says, we are not learning to see into the text for ourselves. We are just learning to copy the work of others. Do the work first. Then check your conclusions against trusted sources. If you adopt this mentality, it may feel slow at first — but the dividends of training to look deeply into the text of Scripture pay off exponentially more than you might expect.

STEP 4: APPLY THE TEXT (10%) THE GOAL

This is the only step that looks at the text with modern eyes. Everything in the first three steps has dealt with the text in its original context — the original author, the original audience, the original meaning. We need to

remember the Bible is written for us, but it is not written to us. There is an original author, an original audience, and an original context that all need to be understood to see the text in its correct setting.

In this last step, we finally ask what the text means for us.

This ordering is critical. If we jump to application before we understand the original meaning, we risk applying a text to our lives in a way the author never intended. The work of Steps 1 through 3 protects us from this methodological error.

Now that we have done the work, we ask:

How can we apply what this passage is saying to our lives today?

Are there principles in this text that translate into modern life?

Does this passage have anything to say to the Church today?

Does it speak to any social or cultural issues in our time?

What specifically are we going to do differently because of what we have studied?

Is there encouragement here that we could share with someone else?

Application is where the study becomes personal. But it only has integrity when it is grounded in the patient, intentional work that came before it.

PART THREE PUTTING IT TOGETHER: AN EXAMPLE STUDY

Now let's use both tools together on a passage many Christians think we already know.

John 3:16.

You can probably recite it. You may have a coffee mug with it on it. It has been displayed on signs at football games and embroidered on throw pillows. It is the most recognized verse in the Bible.

Sadly, however, even those who can quote it from memory have rarely looked deeply at it.

Let's get in the canoe, slow down, and take a look.

STEP 1: SELECTION — DEFINING THE CONTEXT

We are studying John 3:16, but selecting only that verse would cut us off from the context that gives it meaning. The verse does not arrive out of nowhere — it lands in the middle of a late-night conversation between Jesus and a man named Nicodemus. To understand the verse, we need to understand the scene. The broader section is John 3:1–21.

Author: John the Apostle, son of Zebedee and brother of James (Matthew 4:21). He is generally identified as "the disciple whom Jesus loved" (John 21:7).

Audience: Not narrowly identified — John writes to a broad Christian audience.

Placement in the big story: This passage sits squarely in Redemption. Jesus is explaining to a religious leader exactly who He is and what He came to do. What comes before: Jesus has just cleared the Temple (John 2:13–22) and performed signs in Jerusalem that are drawing public attention (John 2:23).

Genre: Narrative — a real conversation between two real people.

STEP 2: OBSERVE — WHAT IS ACTUALLY HERE

Here is where the passage gets interesting. Look at how much is actually in these verses when we slow down.

Who is in this passage?

Nicodemus — a Pharisee and member of the Sanhedrin, the Jewish ruling council (John 3:1). He comes to Jesus at night — possibly to conceal his interest from his colleagues, though this is debated.

Jesus — addressed here as Rabbi, from the Greek word meaning "my great one" — a dual expression of respect and submission to a teacher's authority.

The "we" of verse 2 — Nicodemus implies he is not alone in his conclusions: "we know that you are a teacher who has come from God." Some among the Jewish leadership believed, even if quietly.

Moses — referenced in verse 14, connecting this conversation to a story most readers pass over.

The Son of Man — a messianic title drawn from Daniel 7:13–14, an Old Testament prophecy about the coming king of God's eternal kingdom.

When does this take place?

At night (John 3:2) — the first of three appearances Nicodemus makes in this gospel. He comes to Jesus under cover of darkness. He defends Jesus during the day before the council (John 7:51). By the end, he is in the open, helping to bury Jesus' body (John 19:39). His arc across the gospel is its own quiet story.

Near the time of Passover (John 2:23) — the feast that commemorates God's rescue of Israel from Egypt. The timing is not accidental.

What is happening?

Nicodemus opens by acknowledging Jesus' miraculous signs as evidence that God sent Him. This is a significant admission from a member of the Jewish ruling council that would later condemn Jesus to death. Jesus responds by immediately shifting the conversation to what Nicodemus actually needs: "You must be born again" (John 3:3).

"Born again" — this is the origin of the Christian phrase. The term refers not to a physical rebirth but to a spiritual re-creation at the moment of salvation.

The bronze snake on a pole (verse 14) — this is the detail most readers skip entirely. Look at it. In Numbers 21:4–9, God's people rebelled in the wilderness, and God sent a plague of venomous snakes as a consequence. God then instructed Moses to make a bronze snake and lift it up on a pole. Anyone who looked at it was healed. Jesus uses this story as a direct preview of His own death: He too must be lifted up, so that anyone who looks to Him will live.

Light and darkness — these are major themes running through the entire Gospel of John. Light refers to Jesus (John 1:4–5, 8:12). Darkness refers to sin (John 3:19) and to the condition of those without Christ. John uses these images 23 times in his gospel. Nicodemus first comes to Jesus in the dark. That is not just a time stamp, it's the beginning of Nic's story.

Where does this take place?

Not explicitly stated — but the context places it in or near Jerusalem (John 2:23, 3:22), likely during the Passover festival.

STEP 3: INTERPRET — WHAT DOES IT MEAN?

Literary

"Eternal life" in verse 16 connects directly to the problem established in Genesis 3: sin brought death. Eternal life is the reversal of that sentence.

The word "world" (Greek: kosmos) is sweeping — not just Israel, not just the religious, but the entire human family. The love of God here is not tribal. It is universal in its offer.

Historical

Nicodemus represents the most educated, most religiously privileged person in the Jewish world. He knows the Scriptures. He sits on the highest court. And Jesus tells him that none of it is enough — he must be born again. The implication is not subtle: religious knowledge and institutional standing cannot purchase what only God can give.

Theological

God's love is the motivation. The Son is the means. Faith is the condition. Eternal life is the result. This verse is not a slogan — it is a precise theological statement. God loved first (1 John 4:19). He gave what was most costly. He asks only that we believe. The alternative is not neutral: to not believe is to remain under judgment (verse 18). Nicodemus does not ask whether it is true. He asks how it can be possible (verse 9). He already believes. He just does not yet understand.

STEP 4: APPLY — WHAT DOES IT MEAN FOR US?

John 3:16 is not simply a verse to memorize. It is a claim about the entire structure of reality. God loved the world — which includes every one of us — enough to send His Son as the payment for everything we have done and everything we are. That love is not earned by religious effort. It is received by faith.

A few honest questions to sit with:

Have we received the gift this verse describes, or have we only memorized the words?

Is there someone in our lives who needs to hear this — someone who, like Nicodemus, may be curious but isn't ready to come to Jesus in the full light of day?

The light-and-darkness theme in this passage asks a personal question: are we drawn toward the light, or do we prefer the cover of darkness for certain parts of our lives?

"For God so loved the world that He gave His one and only Son, that whoever believes in Him shall not perish but have eternal life." — John 3:16

We have read this verse many times. Now we have studied it. The difference is the canoe.

WHAT'S NEXT

We now have two tools that will serve us every time we open our Bibles: a framework for understanding the whole story, and a method for studying any passage within it. These are not academic tools reserved for pastors and seminary students. They are for anyone willing to slow down and look carefully.

The S.O.I.L. Method works on every genre of Scripture — narrative, poetry, prophecy, letter, wisdom literature. It works on a single verse or an entire chapter. The more we use it, the more natural it becomes. Over time, we stop thinking about the steps and simply start seeing differently.

That is the goal. This shouldn't just be a method we learn how to use, but rather the development of our spiritual eyes that we use to see deeply into what is in the text of Scripture.

KEEP GOING

If this guide was useful, here are a few next steps:

Try the method on another familiar passage. Romans 8:28. Psalm 23. Matthew 5:3–12. Take your time.

Share this guide with someone in your small group or church who has expressed the same quiet frustration about their Bible reading.

Ask a friend to join you and use the S.O.I.L. method as a group. Studying the Scriptures together with other believers is rewarding and maturing at the same time.

Visit AdelphosAcademy.com

Adelphos Academy offers deeper theological education for everyday believers who want to go further. The same approach that shaped this guide shapes everything we teach there.

The Bible is not waiting for us to be more qualified.

It is waiting for us to slow down.

Happy studying.